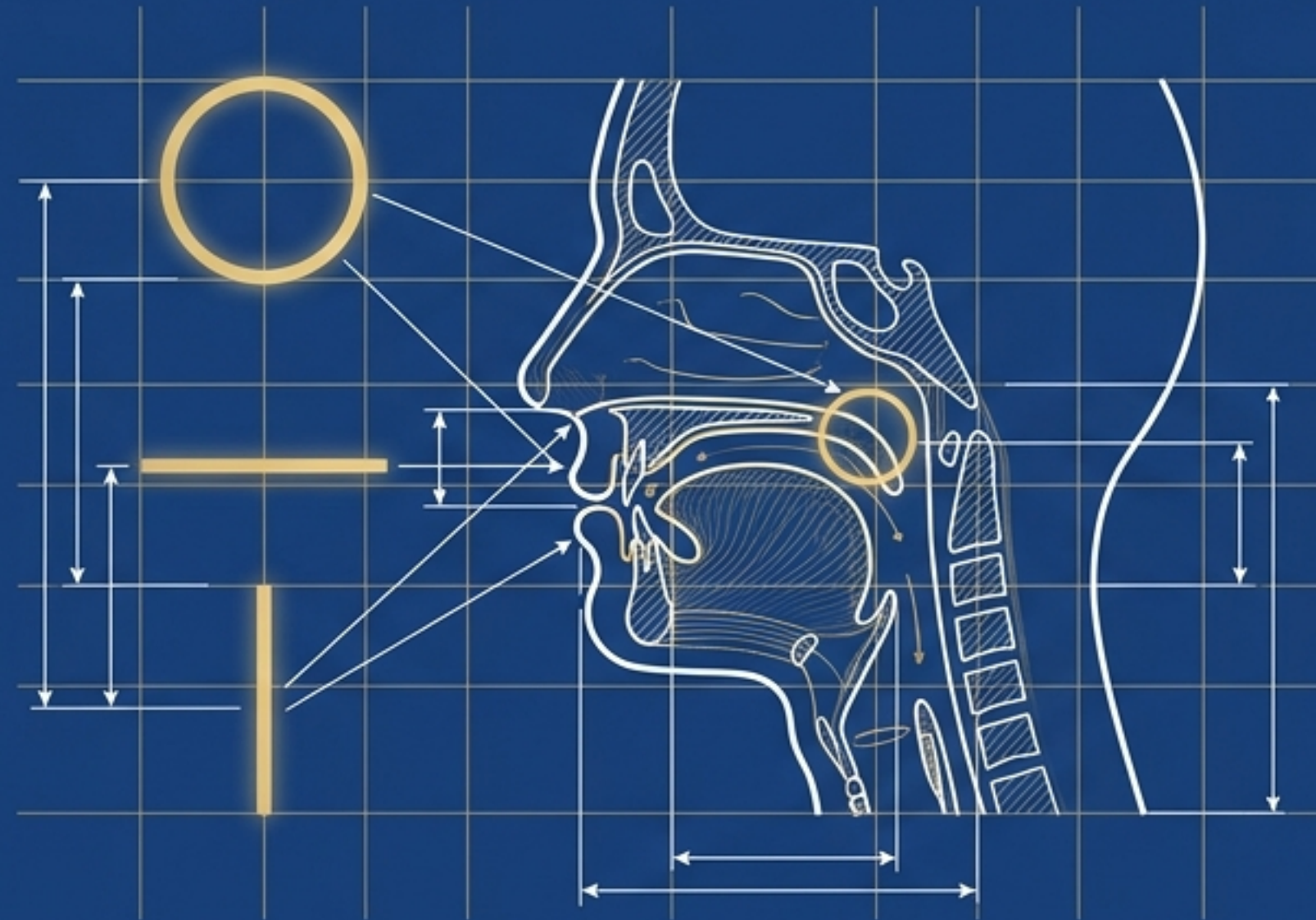


Designing an Alphabet for the People

A case study in empathetic innovation and scientific design under the reign of King Sejong, the fourth king of Joseon.



Illiteracy engineered a culture of silent injustice

During the early Joseon period, the incumbent communication system relied on complex Chinese characters.

The extreme difficulty of this system meant that most common people could neither read nor write.

Without a usable method to record their grievances or understand the law, the people were structurally forced to suffer injustice in silence.



Difficult Chinese Characters

Suffering in Silence

Accessibility

Redesigning the fundamental mechanics of language

The Incumbent System (Chinese Characters)

Design Logic

Ideographic (Requires memorizing thousands of highly complex, distinct characters).

Target User

Elite scholars and officials with decades to study.

Social Impact

Entrenched inequity and voicelessness for the masses.

King Sejong's Vision

Design Logic

Phonetic & Scientific (Combining basic, logical shapes that anyone can learn easily).

Target User

The common people of Joseon.

Social Impact

Democratized communication and societal justice.

The Hall of Worthies operated as a royal research laboratory

A warm heart that loved his people more than anyone

Driven by profound empathy, King Sejong resolved to engineer a new system of letters.

Partnering with the young scholars of the Hall of Worthies, he studied sounds and letters day and night.

King Sejong

Young Scholars of the Jiphyeonjeon

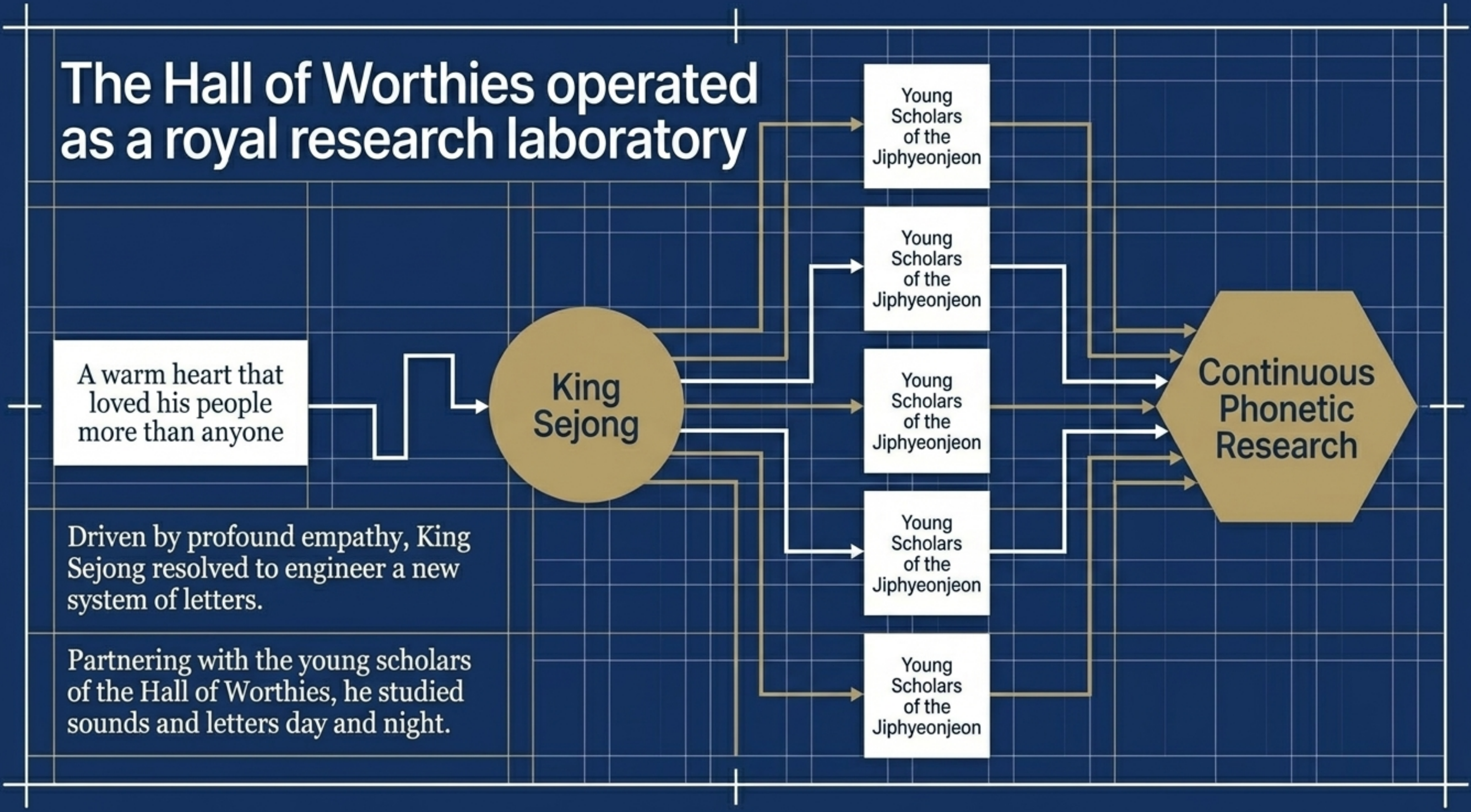
Young Scholars of the Jiphyeonjeon

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Young Scholars of the Jiphyeonjeon

Continuous Phonetic Research



Radical accessibility threatened the institutional power of the elite

Creating a tool that anyone could learn easily was viewed as a threat by the established scholarly class.

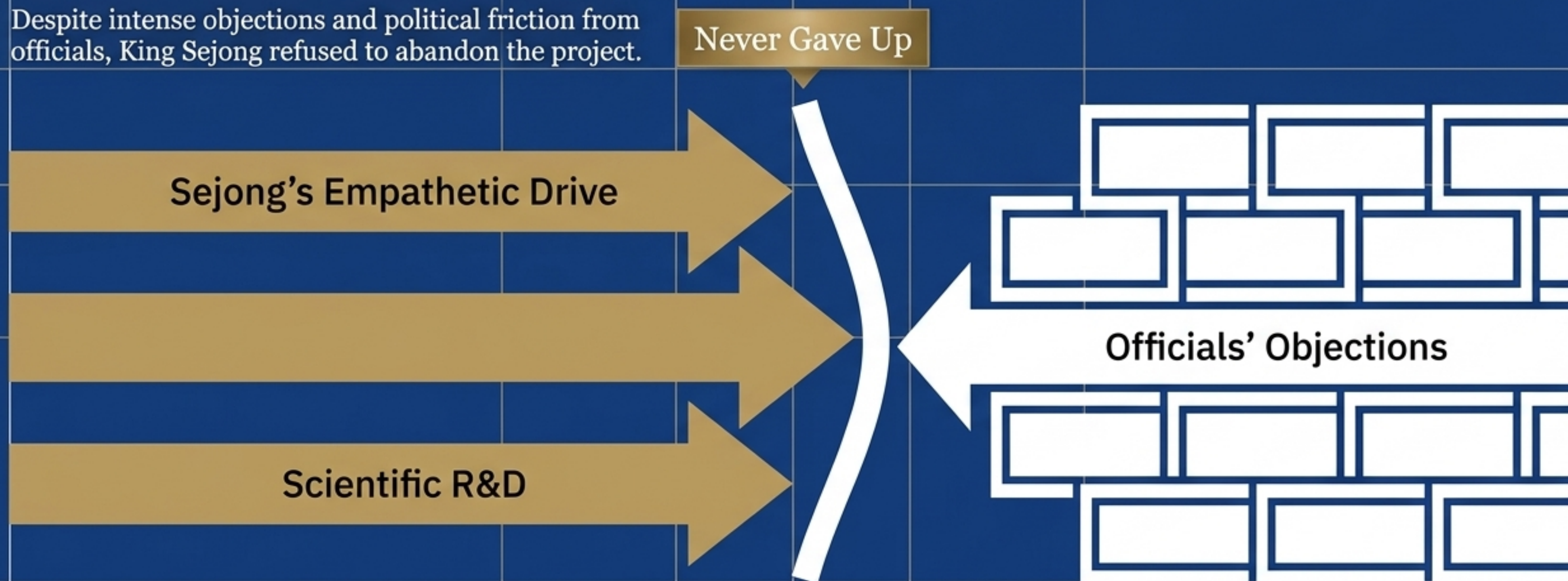
Despite intense objections and political friction from officials, King Sejong refused to abandon the project.

Never Gave Up

Sejong's Empathetic Drive

Scientific R&D

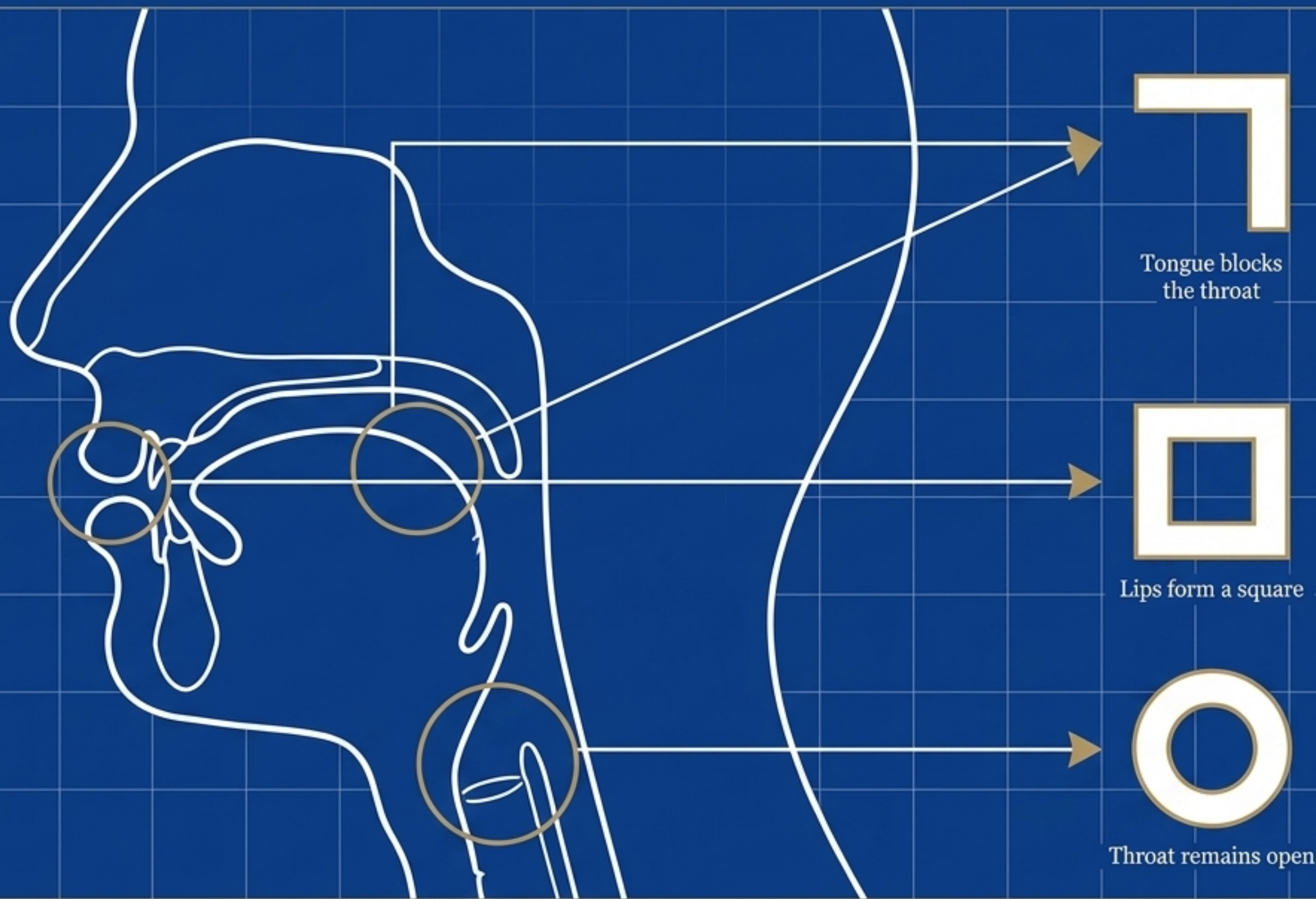
Officials' Objections



Consonants were engineered through anatomical biomimicry

The design of the consonants was modeled directly on the speech organs.

Rather than arbitrary symbols, the letters visually diagram the physical act of speaking, tracking the precise movements of the lips, tongue, and throat.



Vowels were mapped to the fundamental geometry of the cosmos

The vowel system translates philosophical cosmology into a modular UI.

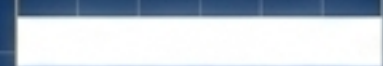
Heaven: Represented by a round dot (·)

Earth: Represented by a flat horizontal line (—)

Human: Represented by an upright vertical line (|)



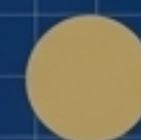
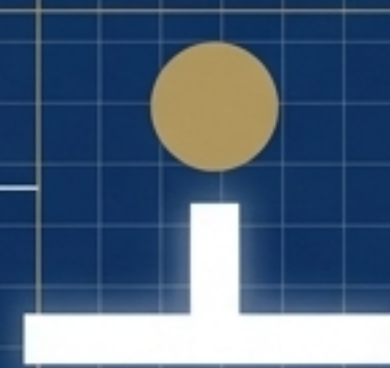
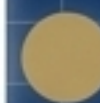
Heaven



Earth



Human



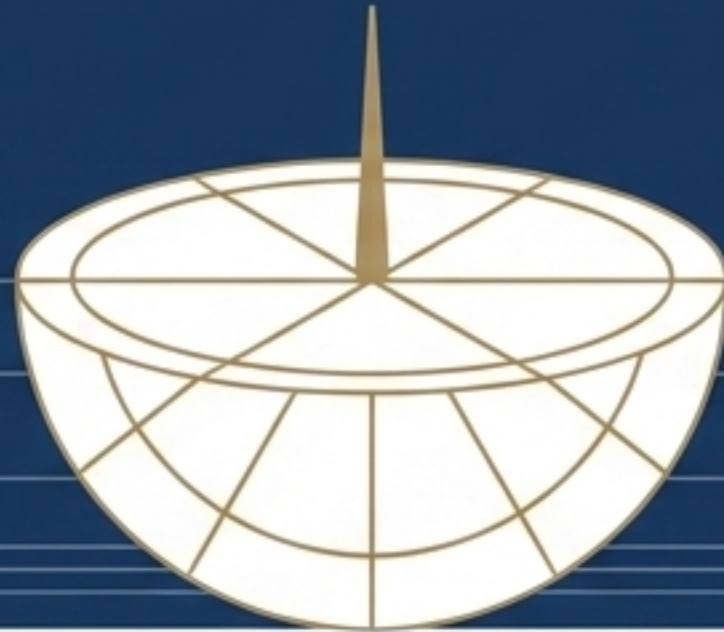
King Sejong officially launched the new letters under the title Hunminjeongeum. The name itself served as a mission statement for the project: The correct sounds to teach the people.

Linguistic design belonged to a broader ecosystem of scientific empowerment

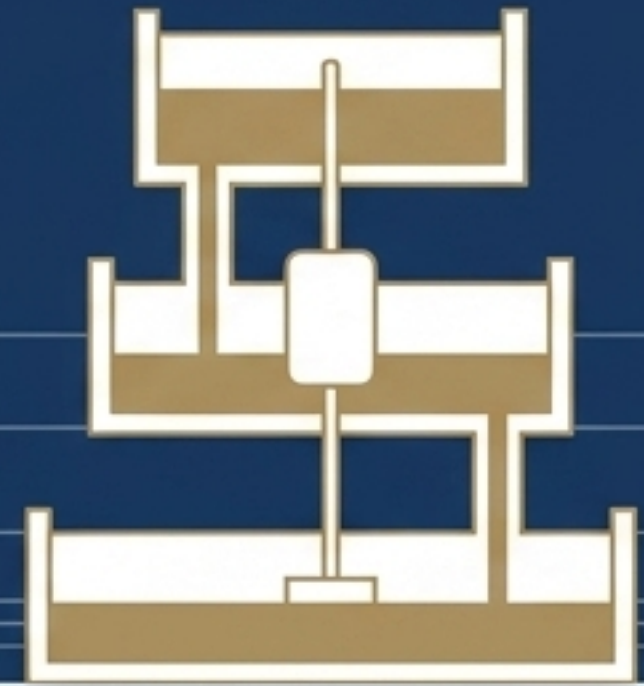
King Sejong's R&D efforts extended far beyond the alphabet. He actively sponsored and invented essential scientific tools, including the rain gauge, the sundial, and the water clock.



Rain Gauge



Sundial



Water Clock

King Sejong systematically democratized the tools of survival

- What connects an alphabet to a rain gauge? They are all technologies designed to remove the friction of daily survival.
- King Sejong identified what his people needed most—the ability to speak out against injustice, track the weather for farming, and measure time—and engineered accessible solutions for all of them.
- It is thanks to this unparalleled legacy of empathetic design that we can learn Korean so easily today.

